

Vincent Lindsay

Alert Investigation - Attempt to turn off Microsoft Defender Antivirus protection

Alert ID: dae61346b5-9c4a-4bda-8f86-5272d4329cdc_1

Severity level: High

Time: 10/01/2026 8:29:13 PM

Hostname: phoenix-vincent-vm

Host IP: 172.16.0.4

User account: Michael Scott

Correlates with: Incident #288 – Compromised Device

Investigation Summary

On 10/01/2026, at 8:26:47 PM CST suspicious account activity pertaining to the user account Michael Scott was detected by Microsoft Defender for Endpoint. Prior to attempting to disable Windows defender entirely, the account was also seen attempting to tamper with settings like Real time monitoring at 8:26:56 PM CST using Powershell.exe. Specifically, on 10/01/2026 at 8:29:13 PM CST, the user account Michael Scott on host phoenix-vincent-vm was seen executing cmd.exe to disable Microsoft Defender Antivirus. Furthermore, this alert follows a chain of events where the account attempted to also tamper with security logs. Based on the logs available we cannot say with confidence if the activity is still on-going.

Who, What, When, Where, Why & How

WHO – User account: Michael Scott

WHAT – Executed cmd.exe to turn off Microsoft Defender Antivirus

WHEN: Based on the alert, the user executed cmd.exe on 10/01/2026 at 8:29:13 PM & attempted to disable Windows Defender.

WHERE: The activity took place on the phoenix-vincent-vm host, with a host IP of 172.16.0.4

WHY: The intent behind the attempt towards the disabling of Windows Defender is not defined, and we cannot say with confidence whether the activity is on-going.

HOW: The user knowingly or unknowingly was involved with multiple suspicious events involving cmd, and PowerShell. Notably, this is the most significant event involving the tampering of defensive tooling.

Correlating Evidence

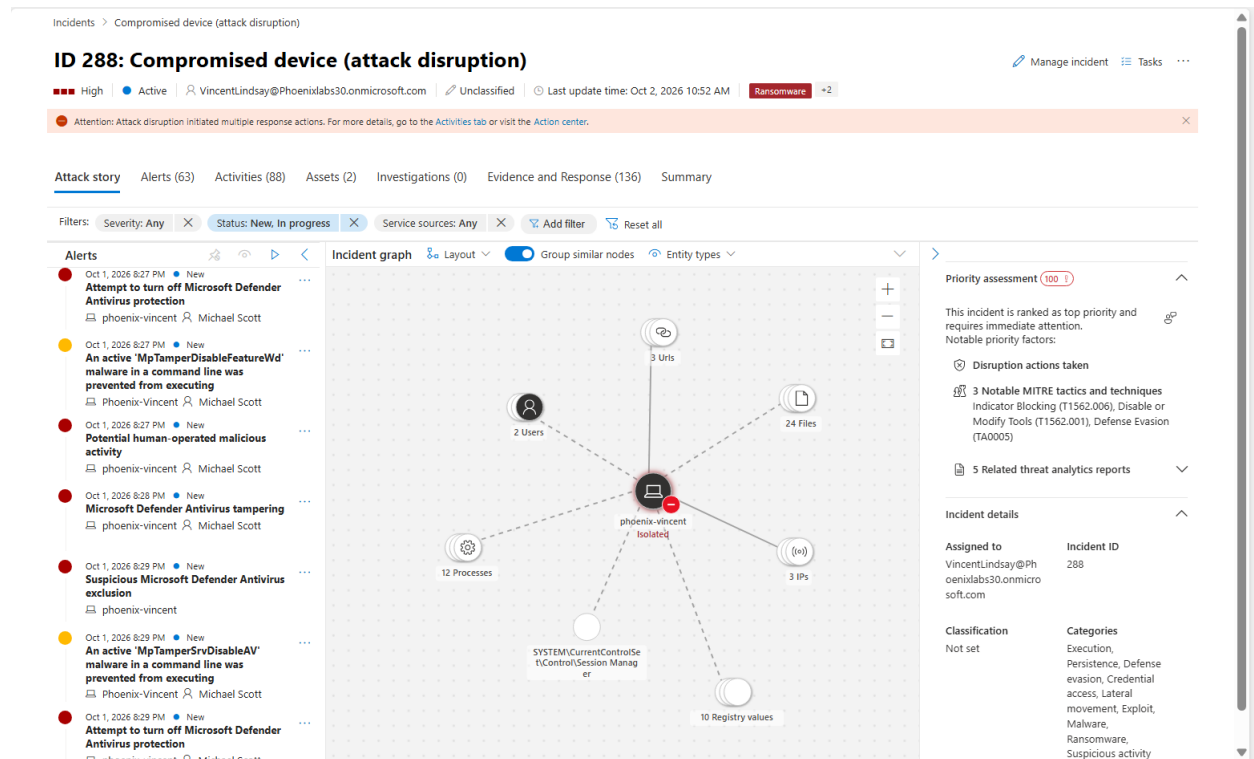


Figure 1: Initial attack summary

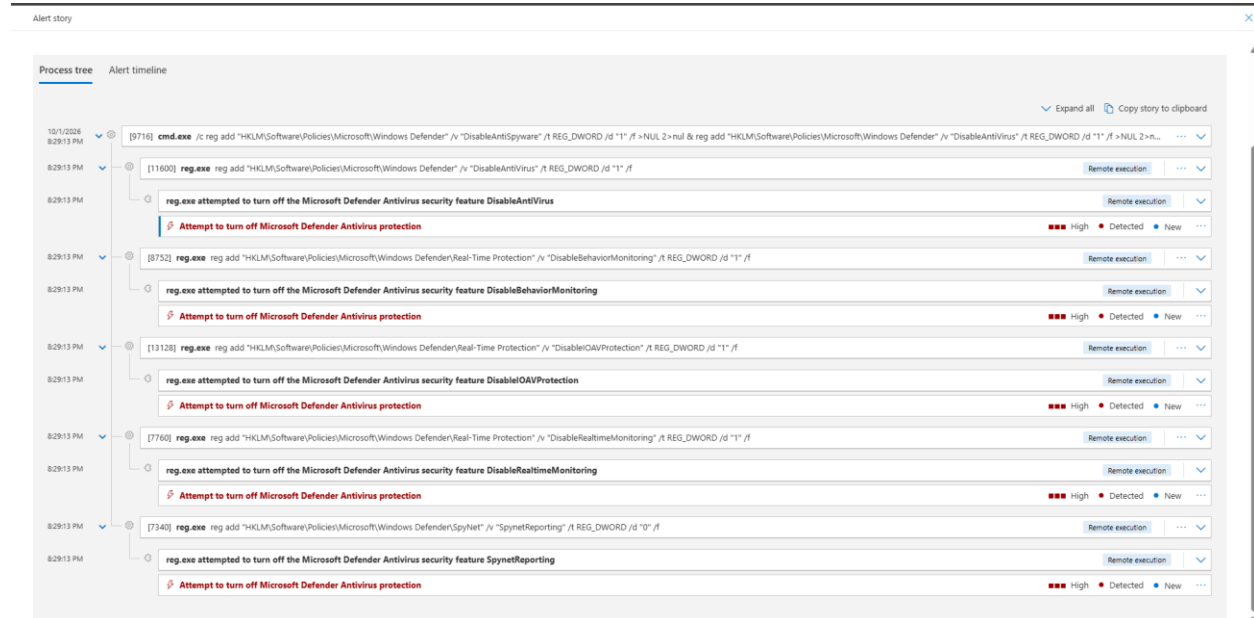


Figure 2: Process tree of alert

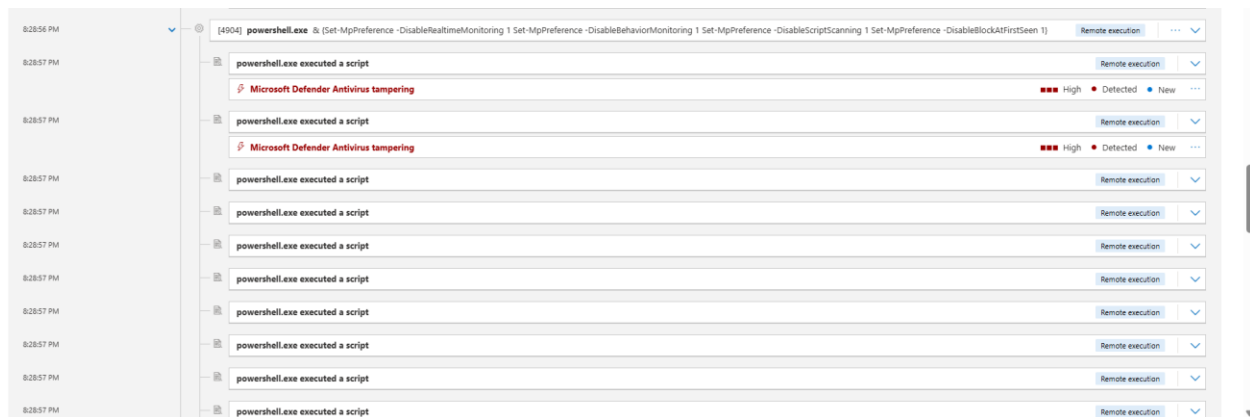


Figure 3: Account attempted to tamper with Windows Defender prior to this alert

☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:39 PM	phoenix-vincent isolated	Isolate Device	Response	phoenix-vincent	Attack Disruption	Automated	Compromised device (at...	●
☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:30 PM	Alert 'An active 'MpTamperSrvDisableAV'...	Alert link	Correlations		Microsoft Defender XDR	Automated		●
☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:30 PM	Alert 'An active 'MpTamperDisableFeatur...	Alert link	Correlations		Microsoft Defender XDR	Automated		●
☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:30 PM	Alert was automatically correlated to inci...	Alert link	Correlations		Automation	Automated	Microsoft Defender Anti...	●
☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:30 PM	Alert was automatically correlated to inci...	Alert link	Correlations		Automation	Automated	An active 'MPTamperAd...	●
☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:30 PM	Alert was automatically correlated to inci...	Alert link	Correlations		Automation	Automated	Potential human-operat...	●
☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:30 PM	Alert was automatically correlated to inci...	Alert link	Correlations		Automation	Automated	An active 'PsAttack' mal...	●
☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:30 PM	Alert was automatically correlated to inci...	Alert link	Correlations		Automation	Automated	Attempt to turn off Micr...	●
☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:30 PM	Alert was automatically correlated to inci...	Alert link	Correlations		Automation	Automated	Possible Antimalware Sc...	●
☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:30 PM	Alert was automatically correlated to inci...	Alert link	Correlations		Automation	Automated	Potential human-operat...	●
☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:30 PM	Alert was automatically correlated to inci...	Alert link	Correlations		Automation	Automated	Potential human-operat...	●
☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:30 PM	Alert was automatically correlated to inci...	Alert link	Correlations		Automation	Automated	Suspicious Microsoft De...	●
☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:30 PM	Incident 289 was automatically merged t...	Incident merge	Correlations		Microsoft Defender XDR	Automated		●
☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:30 PM	Alert 'Possible Antimalware Scan Interfac...	Alert link	Correlations		Microsoft Defender XDR	Automated		●

Figure 4: Defender XDR alerts that show the alert correlation, as well as the isolation of the VM

To identify the specific session associated with the activity, I searched for events relating to the activity.

Query ▶ Run query Create summary rule Create detection rule 100,000 (Default) Last 30 days

```

1 DeviceProcessEvents
2 | where InitiatingProcessSessionId == 2
3 | project TimeGenerated, DeviceName, AccountName, FileName, InitiatingProcessFileName, ProcessCommandLine
4 | where FileName contains "cmd"
5 | where InitiatingProcessFileName contains "powershell"

```

Results Query history Getting started

Export Show empty columns 55 items Search 00:00.847 Low Grid Table Web Full

☐	TimeGenerated	DeviceName	AccountName	FileName	InitiatingProcessFile...	ProcessCommandL...
☐	> Oct 1, 2026 8:28:5...	📁 phoenix-vincent	michaelscott	cmd.exe	powershell.exe	"cmd.exe" /c net.exe sto...
☐	> Oct 1, 2026 8:29:0...	📁 phoenix-vincent	michaelscott	cmd.exe	powershell.exe	"cmd.exe" /c req add "H...
☐	> Oct 1, 2026 8:29:0...	📁 phoenix-vincent	michaelscott	cmd.exe	powershell.exe	"cmd.exe" /c req add "H...
☐	> Oct 1, 2026 8:29:0...	📁 phoenix-vincent	michaelscott	cmd.exe	powershell.exe	"cmd.exe" /c "C:\Progra...
☐	> Oct 1, 2026 8:27:0...	📁 phoenix-vincent	michaelscott	cmd.exe	powershell.exe	"cmd.exe" /c wevtutil cl ...
☐	> Oct 1, 2026 8:27:0...	📁 phoenix-vincent	michaelscott	cmd.exe	powershell.exe	"cmd.exe" /c for /F "toke...
☐	> Oct 1, 2026 8:29:1...	📁 phoenix-vincent	michaelscott	cmd.exe	powershell.exe	"cmd.exe" /c wmic.exe /...
☐	> Oct 1, 2026 8:29:1...	📁 phoenix-vincent	michaelscott	cmd.exe	powershell.exe	"cmd.exe" /c IF EXIST "%...
☐	> Oct 1, 2026 8:29:1...	📁 phoenix-vincent	michaelscott	cmd.exe	powershell.exe	"cmd.exe" /c req add "H...
	TimeGenerated	Oct 1, 2026 8:29:13 PM				
	DeviceName	📁 phoenix-vincent				
	AccountName	michaelscott				
	FileName	cmd.exe				
	InitiatingProcessFileName	powershell.exe				
	ProcessCommandLine	"cmd.exe" /c reg add "HKLM\Software\Policies\Microsoft\Windows Defender" /v "DisableAntiSpyware" /t REG_DWORD /d "1" /f >NUL 2>				
☐	> Oct 1, 2026 8:29:1...	📁 phoenix-vincent	michaelscott	cmd.exe	powershell.exe	"cmd.exe" /c REG ADD ...
☐	> Oct 1, 2026 8:29:1...	📁 phoenix-vincent	michaelscott	cmd.exe	powershell.exe	"cmd.exe" /c req add "H...

Figure 5: Scoping out event timeline

We can see that cmd.exe was used by the Michael Scott account to modify Windows Defender settings.

Query Run query

```

4 DeviceProcessEvents
5 | where InitiatingProcessFileName == "powershell.exe"
6 | where ProcessCommandLine contains "Set-MpPreference"
7 | project TimeGenerated, AccountName, DeviceName, ProcessRemoteSessionIP, InitiatingProcessFileName, ProcessCommandLine

```

Results Query history Getting started

Export Show empty columns 2 items Search 00:02.73 Low

Filters: Add filter

☐	TimeGenerated	AccountName	DeviceName	ProcessRemoteSess...	InitiatingProcessFil...	ProcessCommandL...
☐	Oct 1, 2026 8:28:5...	michaelscott	phoenix-vincent	192.168.1.158	powershell.exe	"powershell.exe" & {Set-MpPreference -Disa... Set-MpPreference -Disa... Set-MpPreference -Disa... Set-MpPreference -Disa...

TimeGenerated	Oct 1, 2026 8:28:57 PM
AccountName	michaelscott
DeviceName	phoenix-vincent
ProcessRemoteSessionIP	192.168.1.158
InitiatingProcessFileName	powershell.exe
ProcessCommandLine	"powershell.exe" & {Set-MpPreference -DisableRealtimeMonitoring 1 Set-MpPreference -DisableBehaviorMonitoring 1 Set-MpPreference -DisableScriptScanning 1 Set-MpPreference -DisableBlockAtFirstSeen 1}

Figure 6: confirming malicious activity

Furthermore, we can see that the account attempted to use PowerShell to Disable Windows Defender settings.

Recommendations

- 1) Contain and investigate the Michael Scott account
 - Temporarily disable or restrict the Michael Scott account and review recent authentication activity, logons, and sessions to determine whether the account was compromised or intentionally used to perform the activity.
 - Reset the account's credentials and review MFA status before restoring normal access.
- 2) Maintain endpoint isolation and verify Defender protections

- If the endpoint was not Isolated, perform Isolation of the endpoint.
- Verify that Microsoft Defender Antivirus, Real-Time Protection, and other security controls have been restored and cannot be disabled by the affected user.

3) Perform additional scoping and threat hunting

- Review activity immediately before and after the Defender tampering for additional use of PowerShell, cmd.exe, security-log manipulation, or other defense-impairment techniques.
- Search across the environment for similar Defender configuration changes, suspicious PowerShell commands, and activity associated with the Michael Scott account to determine whether the incident is isolated to this endpoint or part of a broader compromise.